

times are good, it's hard to tell whether the sock puppets selling pet food on the Internet are truly a good idea or just lucky for a little while.

Uneven hiring pattern across sectors

The probability of hiring among all the sectors of the Indian electronics industry follows a Gaussian pattern rather than a flat one. While most of them are staggering from the effects of the economic slowdown, power electronics and telecom are the one's showing considerable promise of growth. As these sectors strive for growth and expansion, their manpower needs also increase simultaneously.

The steady rise of the power electronics sector can be attributed to the ever-present need for infrastructure. As corporate majors look to cut costs and increase productivity, the one way they are likely to achieve this is through introduction of cost-effective power electronics solutions.

The telecom sector, on the other hand, owes its expansion more to aggressive marketing and falling tariff leading to cut-throat competition. Further scope of expansion exists as the major players in the sector begin to enter the hitherto untapped rural market and wireless broadband service.

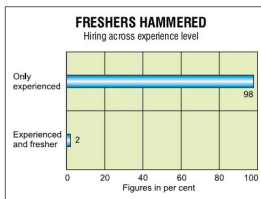
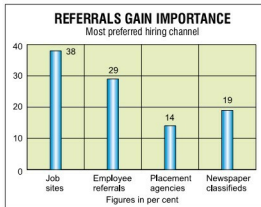
It is worth noting that trading houses are at the lowest end of the hiring curve.

More skills in demand

More and more firms seem inclined to 'poach' experienced professionals rather than do the hard work of training and grooming freshers.

"Although the telecom industry is booming and creating a lot of opportunities, considering the economic slowdown, companies would prefer to go with experienced hands," says Pius Maria Prasad, director-human resource, Huawei Technologies India.

However, firms are more inclined to invest time and resource in training their existing workforce. Around 73 per cent of the firms surveyed were



prioritising investment in training of middle- and higher-level management as a means of future-proofing their business against global competition. This approach helps to strengthen sector-specific expertise in the long term and even encourage companies to consider collaboration with relevant academic partners.

Very few firms tend to hire freshers, with most such as Cadence Design Systems providing free internship at best. So what should the freshers do if they haven't been hired as yet? Ideally, they should have a more practical approach. Working for unpaid projects could be a wise option to showcase their talent. It may come in handy when things turn around.

Further, the "doing more with less" policy is evident as companies raise the bar of expectation. New-age employers prefer to conceive a prospective employee as a complete package endowed with more than one specific skill. Employees at middle level are required to

take up more responsibilities in ensuring timeliness, quality and process adherence of their deliverables. They now need to show value-additions in their work.

Companies are also finding it necessary to attract niche skills. In the field of R&D especially, while hiring of candidates with mere generic skills will reduce considerably, people with additional niche skills will remain in demand. The more the qualifications you have, the more the opportunities you can grab for yourself.

There are demands from the professionals as well. Apart from the usual expectations pertaining to remuneration, there is also the demand in some quarters, especially from design engineers, for a flexible work environment. Alternative work schedules or flexi work timings seem to be the primary demand along with compressed hours of the week – work for the same hours in lesser number of days.

Vacancies being reviewed

The usual channels of recruitment remain the mainstay of the industry. On-line recruitment sites were the most popular with at least 38 per cent of respondents going for the popular job sites. Newspaper classifieds and headhunters were also common sources with most firms, while employee referrals turned out to be a significant source among SMEs.

The companies, though, are going ahead with their plans to maintain a sizable workforce that's needed to run their operations. But one change in hiring strategy is evident. While there is no blanket freeze on order, every vacancy is being reviewed for its immediate justification. ●

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